



SUMMER CAMPS





a Society for Promotion of
Inclusive and Relevant Education



Aspire began in 2014 as a non-profit organization with a vision of a society bearing the will and the means to meet the democratic right of children to education. Aspire's mission is to assist all members of a community with enhancing their participation in meeting the educational needs of their children. Aspire has partnered with TATA Steel Foundation and The Hans Foundation to create a sustainable and holistic model that addresses every stakeholder in education, from the children, parents and schools, to community members, Panchayati Raj institutions and district administration. This model has proven itself beyond expectations in the four years since its inception. Aspire is now expanding its horizons and reaching out to more people than ever before, with the hope to affect perpetual change in their lives.



ORIGIN

The philosophy of Aspire's interventions is centred on a holistic engagement of all stakeholders in education, and catalyzing change through successful demonstrations of mutual cooperation between them. Aspire's summer camps embody this catalysis by bringing people from all backgrounds together for a massive, coordinated mobilization of resources and effort.

Aspire's summer camps have an inspiring history. The early success of Aspire's Learning Enrichment Programme (LEP) in eight blocks of Odisha and Jharkhand had created a demand for wider coverage of Aspire's interventions in schools. As Aspire's activities in the regions were in their infancy and resources were limited, an alternate solution was required to answer this demand.

Summer camp was the answer. While the resources to engage almost every school in the eight blocks were not there, a much wider geographical and institutional engagement could be endured for a shorter period. Constant dialogue with stakeholders like parents and teachers had revealed that parents and teachers alike wanted children to be fruitfully engaged during the summer holidays. Teachers complained that children lose touch with their academic progress during summer vacations, and parents found it difficult to accommodate them in anything except livelihood and domestic work. Summer camps offered a radical new avenue to energize children through a novel mix of learning and play. Summer camps also gave Aspire a chance to reach out to schools untouched by the learning enrichment programme by giving them a taste of its unique pedagogical ensemble. This helped in galvanizing support for the programme extensively and more evenly throughout the blocks adopted by Aspire.

ASPIRE'S SUMMER CAMPS – A GLIMPSE

Every step in the organization of Aspire's summer camps yields concrete benefits. Aspire believes in giving the community a sense of ownership of its collective efforts. In sight of this goal, the organization of summer camps also takes place largely through democratic processes intrinsic to the community and provisions of decentralized governance. For example, school premises are used as summer camp venues, and the usage of school premises requires the cognizance and approval of district education officials. This approval is sought by the school management committees of the different schools, which unite in raising this demand. Aspire has successfully encouraged several hundred school management committees to negotiate with local government officials like the Block Education Officer (BEO), the Community Resource Centre Coordinator (CRCC) etc. For many schools, this mobilization is often the first step taken towards the revitalization of school management committees with Aspire's support.

Human resources for the summer camps are sought from the local population itself. The youth volunteer as teachers for the summer camp, and receive adequate training from Aspire before the beginning of the camp. Many youth discover a renewed sense of social purpose after their stint as a volunteer teacher, and go on to become fully employed teachers, either in government schools or as part of Aspire's staff.

Turnout for Aspire's summer camps has been very high, with 92% of all children from elementary schools attending the summer camp regularly. This sets a very high standard to the community and raises their aspirations for what is possible in terms of creating an attractive educational ecosystem. Community members are now increasingly raising a demand for extension of summer schools to all elementary schools and classes in the regions.



ASPIRE'S SUMMER CAMPS – A GLIMPSE

One of the biggest advantages of summer camps is that, unlike regular school, the bridging centres or the learning enrichment programme run by Aspire, summer camps are consistently accessible to parents, and allow them to see for themselves how a class is conducted. Parents frequently visit summer camp sites and interact with the class, and occasionally participate in activities. They see how their children take interest in the activities and subjects, enjoy themselves, and acquire different tastes and skills. This goes a long way in reinforcing the value attributed to elementary education in the community, and helps in expediting the eradication of child labour, combating inconsistency of attendance in schools, reducing dropout rates and boosting the gross enrolment ratio.

Panchayati Raj institutions are also engaged in the process, as the children attendees of summer camps are tallied with the village education registers maintained by the Gram Panchayats with Aspire's help. This exercise prepares panchayats officials for other long-term commitments to the audit of elementary education and child rights in their jurisdiction.

Government officials, politicians and other important figureheads make occasional visits to summer camp sites. The positivity they witness at the summer camp helps motivate them to work towards attaining quality public education besides enhancing their receptivity to Aspire's multiple educational interventions.

Most importantly, summer camps give children and instructors space to explore different modes of relevant and context-dependent learning, unrestricted by a straight-jacketed syllabus. Children partake in different educational activities like singing, extempore, art, drama, role-playing and other games that make rich use of teaching and learning materials. While summer camps do have weekly learning plans, the objective of summer camps is to impart practical knowledge and skills like calendar reading, sentence construction and awareness about health issues, water management and sustainable development. This serves the dual purposes of raising children's learning achievements to a level suitable for their age and class, and giving them skills and knowledge that, while not strictly academic, make them aware, responsible, independent and adaptive individuals.





OBJECTIVES

While Aspire's summer camps serve multiple ends, they primarily achieve the following objectives –

- ❖ Keeping children in touch with their academic progress in schools;
- ❖ Providing parents and community members a rare window to children's classroom experiences;
- ❖ Fruitfully engaging youth and community members in a programme that instils a sense of purpose and social ambition in them;
- ❖ Imparting remedial, contextual, interactive and skill-based instruction to augment children's awareness, independence, creativity and adaptivity.

COVERAGE

Aspire's summer camps have achieved monumental success. More than 20000 children are part of Aspire's summer camp every year. With the extension of summer camps to children from middle school, this number can only be expected to increase. Aspire engages over 900 youth volunteers during summer camps. In the run-up to the summer camp, above 750 school management committees mobilize resources and attain permits from the government for hosting the summer camp.

The 2019 summer camp saw an unprecedented 29000 children participate in summer camps, with attendance rates as high as 100% during the 40 days. More than 950 camp sites were arranged this year, engaging close to 900 personnel including volunteers and staff.

The opening and closing ceremonies were graced by political leaders, bureaucrats, figures from industries and association heads, which lent the programme the visibility it deserves.

All of this has been achieved in less than three years since the inception of summer camps. With each passing year, Aspire is perfecting its summer camp model and making it feasible for deployment in other regions and by other civil society organizations. The initiative shows much promise, and the journey forward seems to be an uphill one.





STRUCTURE AND ACTIVITIES

Aspire's summer camps extend for a period of forty days during the summer vacations in public schools. Camps are organized at school premises, besides other sites. The daily duration of a summer camp is typically between three to four hours, with camp beginning sometime between 6 am and 7 am in the morning, and ending at 10 am.

Every camp site is headed by an instructor, who is either a volunteer, a member of Aspire's staff, or a teacher-on-training. Children from multiple classes sit together in a class, where they are engaged together or distinctly by the instructor as she/he sees fit, depending on the lesson plan. Instructors receive adequate training before the commencement of summer camp, and stick to a predesigned weekly lesson plan.

A summer camp session consists of a wide-array of activities. Children practice reading and comprehension, and are often compete in intra-class extempore contests to practice public speaking skills. *Balgeet*, which are song-and-dance routines tailored to children's performances, are a regular feature in camp sessions. Children also occasionally compete in debate competitions, often with community members for an audience, where they argue on socially relevant issues like child labour, child marriage etc. Children also participate in discussions about important contemporary themes such as water management and health awareness. Discussions on Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) are a novel and unique feature of Aspire's summer camps.

Games serve multiple purposes in summer camps. Games like *Matrakhadi* help children enhance their grammar and language skills, while other games like 'number counting' enhances basic arithmetic skills. There are also games like 'story chain' which encourage and exhibit children's imagination and creative thinking.

ACHIEVEMENTS

Block	Number of centres	Number of volunteer teachers
Danagadi	146	146
Sukinda	132	74
Harichandanpur	154	154
Joda	167	167
Koida	96	90
Kutra	82	78
Noamundi	93	*
Jagannathpur	101	**
Total	971	***

*, **, *** : Data not available

Block	Total schools	Schools participating in summer camp	Percentage of schools participating in summer camp
Danagadi	173	120	72.9
Sukinda	162	108	66.0
Harichandanpur	239	128	53.5
Joda	193	130	67.3
Koida	160	78	48.7
Kutra	115	68	59.1
Noamundi	118	71	60.1
Jagannathpur	118	66	55.9
Total	1278	769	60.1

Block	Total eligible children	Total children participating in summer camp	Percentage of children covered
Danagadi	4549	4029	88.5
Sukinda	4774	4019	84.1
Harichandanpur	4180	4180	100
Joda	5566	5566	100
Koida	3158	2687	85
Kutra	2636	2300	87.2
Noamundi	3386	3083	91.1
Jagannathpur	3991	3637	91.5
Total	32240	29501	91.5

- ‘Total schools’ refers to the total number of schools with classes 3, 4, 5, 6 and 7.
- ‘Number of centres’ refers to the total number of summer camp centres/sites.
- ‘Schools participating in summer camp’ refers to total number of schools of which the students from classes 3, 4 and 5 attended, and premises were used for, summer camp.
- ‘Total eligible children’ refers to children in classes 3, 4 and 5 enrolled in the schools in the block.
- ‘Enrolled children’ refers to the total number of students who were part of Aspire’s summer camp classes.